THE LOVE AND HATE OF BLING PRODUCTS
AN INDUSTRIAL DESIGN STUDENT CASE

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ABSTRACT

There are many different factors that influence our perception of products i.e. personal, product related and external factors. For designers to be able to address them all when creating new products, we need to deepen our understanding of the totality of perceptual experiences from non-instrumental interaction with products. One way of achieving this is by stimulating the creative process by utilising provocation. We have explored how industrial design students interacted with a product category with special product characteristics, namely Bling products. These products generate a lot of attention and emotional reactions, people seem to either love or hate them. In order to understand this love-hate relationship to Bling products and by using provocation as a starting point, we analysed nine industrial design student projects on the theme of 'future Bling'. Self-reflective reports on the students' design projects were categorized with the help of the Perceptual Product Experience framework (PPE). Although the students' were confronted with a product type they initially disliked, we found that they transformed their perception of Bling both regarding pleasure aspects (e.g. how and why the product stimulates our senses) and meaning aspects (e.g. what the product represents or which value we ascribe to it) of perceptual experiences. Furthermore, according to the students' self-reflective reports, they felt they managed to use this transformation as a source of inspiration and driving force in their design process.

Keywords: product identity, product experiences, provocation, Bling, design student cases

INTRODUCTION

Whatever we perceive (i.e. take in to our sensory system through external stimuli) and experience (responses which arise as a result of perceived stimuli), can either be characterised as being primarily related to sensory input, processing and making sense of such input, or as emotional and value based response to input. For example, we may regard ecologically grown tomatoes to be smaller in size but tastier compared to conventionally cultivated alternatives. As they require a long distance transport from their source however, the good feeling of having done an environmentally conscious choice is somewhat challenged in the process, and we may be unsure what the most sustainable alternative really is. In a situation like this, we experience what we perceive from two points of view, the presentational and the representational (Warell, 2008).

The presentational aspect is pleasure-dominated; the experience is primarily dependent on compositional and morphological criteria such as how and why they stimulate our senses and catch our attention, as well as the emotional response (Warell, 2008) i.e. the valence dimension displeasure-pleasure, or arousal dimension deactivated-activated (Russell, 1980, 2003). For example, the organic tomato might not look as good as the conventionally grown alternative and the initial emotional response may be of the rejecting kind, further augmented by the higher price.

The representational aspect on the other hand, is meaning-dominated; the experience is caused by processes of recognising, remembering, and attributing value to perceptions. Here, narratives, storytelling and cultural aspects come into play in

shaping our perceptions and determining the experience (Warell, 2008). Thus, the ecological message of the organic tomato and the ethical and environmental values it stands for will influence our decision contributing to a more sustainable world, rather than choosing the greenhouse-cultivated option. Consequently, when we interact with products there is a variety of factors that influence our experience. As a designer you need to address them all.

In this paper we explore the love and hate relationship to products exemplified by a product category which is characterized by an extreme product identity, Bling products. Our earlier experiences have demonstrated that designers become provoked by Bling products (Christoforidou et al, 2012). Hence, Bling products trigger their subconscious values on good and bad taste. Thereby constitute a threat to designers' opinions on good taste, they provoke.

The more intense the reaction is to a provocation, the more deeply rooted the broken convention (Garfinkel, 1967). Hence, provocations can be used as a driving force for creativity in a design process. This can be compared to de Bono's (1973) 'Po' concept and Garfinkel's (1967) 'breaching experiments' which both aim to challenge attitudes or common social values and norms; to break conventions and support processes of lateral and creative thinking. During a thought-provoking workshop and inspired by de Bono's "Po" (1973) and Garfinkel's (1967) "breaching experiments", we challenged industrial design students' attitude regarding bad taste, with the hope to stimulate the level of creativity during the design process, i.e. by using Bling products as a 'breach'.

To be able to elucidate how designers could work with extremes such as "love" and "hate" and thereby influence the creation of strong bonds to products, we have analysed design projects carried out by industrial design students on the theme of future Bling concepts, a theme that took the students by surprise. As a starting point to our exploration of love-hate relations to products we mapped the students' self-reflective reports on their design process with the help of a categorization model, the Perceptual Product Experience framework (PPE, Warell, 2008), compared to other frameworks, the PPE framework addresses multiple dimensions of product experiences. Thereby, we can take into account how the students perceived product experiences from two different perspectives: the presentational (e.g. how and why a product stimulates our senses) and the representational (e.g. what meaning or which value we attribute to a product). This will help us understand how and why Bling products provoke designers to such extent. Such knowledge will help us identify future provocations to work with within the design education context in order to encourage students and stimulate their creativity in the design processes further?

THE PRESENTATIONAL ASPECTS OF BLING PRODUCT

People strive to achieve "good taste", and see beauty as something elevated and divine (Bourdieu, 1984). Since the days of Plato, people have been influenced by the argument that true beauty resides in the *idea* of Beauty (Plato, 1997). Although the arguments nowadays are expressed slightly different compared to Plato's ambition to explain the perception of things around us, people still adopt values indicating that ideas are more valuable and beautiful than actions., Norman (2004), for instance claims that products' beauty emanates from the user's *conscious reflection* and experience influenced by knowledge, learning, and culture. When it comes to the designed product, it is often pointed out that a product must have a content and not merely appearance (Vihma, 2007). For example, the product should be well worked-out from a holistic perspective, i.e., thoughts about the product are more crucial than its creation (Ask, 2004). Furthermore, merely imitating something that already exists contributes with less value to a product compared with a product's innovative aspects that reflect the designer's underlying intention (Vihma, 2007; Crilly, 2005). Crozier (1994) argues that objects are considered to have status and value when identified as being 'designed'. In this way, design is given meaning as a lifestyle, something aesthetically pleasing or fashionable. However, in 'being' designed lies also an opportunity for designers to play, challenge and or question with infusing products with status as a result of being an expression for beauty and consequently good taste. Hence, in that way

designers may influence the prerequisites for creating love and hate relationships to products.

According to Plato, Beauty was closely linked and even equated to the Good and True (Plato, 1997). Ugliness, on the contrary, should according to Sandqvist (1998) not be dismissed; what is ugly is also alive. People are attracted to ugliness because it is alive and filled with delight. Ugliness escapes the demand for credibility, and is allowed to express itself and play (Sandqvist, 1998). This makes bad taste more tolerant, 'mischievous', and provides more joy than good taste, which labours under the demands of maintaining the true, the divine (Ivanov, 2004). Sandqvist (1998) describes ugliness as the reason for beauty, not its antithesis or negation. Consequently, for designers' designing products with the connotation to ugliness and bad taste can be seen as an opportunity to initiate discussions that trigger our subconscious values (cf. Ahl and Olsson, 2002).

The word 'Bling' is used to represent a lifestyle where it is important to signal wealth in a straight-forward manner through ostentatious consumption (Ossé and Tolliver, 2006), and as such it is connected to prejudices and social values. The psychological motivations behind conspicuous consumption and the term as such were explored and coined by Thorstein Veblen (1994/1899). In the pursuit of superior social status, conspicuous consumption is the behavior whereby one displays great wealth by means of idleness — expending much time in the practice of leisure activities, and spending considerable sum of money to consume luxury goods and services (Veblen, 1994/1899, Trigg 2001).

Bling products may be associated to and confused with kitsch as they both stand for 'bad taste' and share similar dynamics and motivations in relation to status and hierarchies (cf. Bourdieu, 1984). Norbert Elias (1935) traced the origins of the term 'kitsch' in Munich in the beginning of the twentieth century. The term was adopted by art specialist to characterize the type of commercial art that was popular among American tourists. Eventually, parasitical and poor imitations of fine arts, tasteless, mass-produced, sentimental, trashy, vulgar and cheap objects were called 'kitsch' (Dorfles, 1968; Cieraad and Porte, 2003; Londos, 2003). Some art critics (i.e. Dorfles, 1968) used the term 'kitsch' interchangeably with 'bad taste'. While Bling products in the proper sense can be understood by the help of Veblen's (1994/1899) and Bourdieu's (1984) ideas on conspicuous consumption, habitus and cultural capital and are furthermore part of a lifestyle and a subculture; it is mainly the 'fake' Bling products that can be perceived as and treated as synonymous to kitsch. Kitsch eludes categorization under conventional definitions and belongs therefore to the genre of 'wild things' (Attfield, 2003.) As such, it is quite possible kitsch could work as a successful 'breach'. However, since the 60s', kitsch is part of contemporary culture and contextualized as an aspect of 'popular taste' (Attfield, 2003). Therefore, its provocative power has somewhat lost its edge.

Originally, 'Bling' is an onomatopoetic slang term from Jamaica that imitates the imaginary 'sound' of light when hitting and being reflected by a diamond (Wikipedia, 2008). However, today is Bling associated to American rap artists and is usually employed to describe glittering jewellery that indicates wealth: showy diamond rings, large golden necklaces and accessories. Hence, the diamonds represent the ultimate prize, the height of success, the glittering finale (Duffy, 2003). To summarize; Bling products shout out their message: bigger is better, more is better, glitzier is better (Christoforidou and Olander, 2009). Consequently, Bling products can be interpreted only by a superficial exposure of status linked to appearance without any connection to Plato's world of ideas and thereby the truly beautiful. Bling represents products where the appearance and not products' content is in focus. Bling is therefore perceived as a direct opposite to products representing good taste (Christoforidou et al, 2012).

THE REPRESENTATIONAL ASPECTS OF BLING PRODUCT

Some products are easier accepted and better appreciated by the user than others. We forge relationships to products around us all the time and some of these relationships are stronger than others, generating strong emotions such as love and hate. Schifferstein et al. (2004) define the strength of such a relationship as the user having an emotional bond to specific products, the user feels attached to the

product. One way for designers to create product attachment when designing new products according to Mugge (2007), is to let the individual invest some of him or herself into the product by personalization. According to Ahuvia (2005), many precious objects result in an identity crisis for their users. Such objects are linked to the self – both as expressions of the current self and simultaneously as contributors to the alteration of the self into a more desired form. However, what one prefers or not, is related to one's person. Hence, taste is associated with a person's experience of the self in the way that taste reflects that person's innermost self. Therefore, by extension, taste reveals a person's inner self to others (Crozier, 1994).

One strong characteristic of Bling is the quantitative aspect, i.e. more is better. One single diamond is not Bling, an excessive number of diamonds in infinite repetition however, is (Christoforidou et al, 2012). Brunius (1961) argues that boredom caused by repetition can be the enemy of beauty. Brunius (1961) arguments on aesthetic taste could provide one explanation as to why people in design circles are provoked by Bling (Christoforidou and Olander, 2009). Discussions on Bling raise questions and elicit discomfort (Christoforidou et al, 2012); they lead to debate and defence of the participants' own lifestyles (Abelsson, 1986). Individuals feel ill at ease when being in environments and contexts where their own values and lifestyles are questioned (Giddens, 1997). Consequently, Bling products might be considered as a threat to good taste (cf. Veblen, 1994/1899 and Bourdieu, 1984).

THE PERCEPTUAL PRODUCT EXPERIENCE FRAMEWORK (PPE)

During the latest decennium, design research has focused a great deal on product experience. Consequently, there are many different frameworks attempting to explain product experience: e.g. Jordan (2000) describes product experiences in relation to of a product as a result of it being sufficiently 'different' to stand out.

Appreciation is about "recognition of aesthetic values" (Merriam-Webster, 2008). In the PPE framework, pleasure whereas Desmet (2002) proceed from emotions in relation to product experiences. Furthermore, by mapping consumers' responses and designers' intentions, Crilly (2005) describes how we can understand and interpret products. Common ground for these frameworks explaining product experience, is that they all focus on one dimension of product experience: Jordan (2000) and Desmet (2002) on the affective level, whereas Crilly's (2005) main focus lies on the cognitive level.

Experiences are considered subjective and specific to each perceiver, and depend on personal factors (experiences, background, cultural values and motives), product related factors (type of product, properties and characteristics, brand), and external factors (environmental, social and economic context). The perceptual product experience (PPE framework structures experiences as being brought about through processes of sensory, cognitive, or affective stimuli and response (Warell, 2008). Furthermore, the PPE framework regards perceptual product experience as composed of three core modes; the sensorial, the cognitive, and the affective modes of experience (see figure 1). The three core modalities recognise all possible types of perceptual experience of products and other phenomena including: (1) initial impression and recognition of product existence and specific perceptual characteristics, (2) making sense of the product, its manifestation, structure, use, origin and purpose, and (3) the affective response, attribution of value to, and judgment of the product.

Within these dimensions and the core modes, the framework distinguishes between six experiential modes. These are briefly presented in the following.

Impression is the essential and first part of the experience, which in turn can lead to any, or all, of the other experiences. In the PPE framework, impression is the purely sensorial experience of becoming aware

appreciation engages cognitive processing of what we perceive through our senses.

Emotion is the affective response evoked by the combination of product stimuli, subjective concerns and an appraisal (Desmet, 2002). Furthermore

emotions are a result of our assessment or appraisal of the product in light of our experience and concerns related to it (Desmet, 2002).

The three modes of the representation dimension are related to the three types of semiotic signs: icon, index and symbol (Peirce, 1966). There is however no absolute mapping between the type of sign and the form of representation (Warell et al. 2006).

Recognition is based on direct, instantaneous processing of perceived stimuli – perception and recognition are inseparably intertwined (Arnheim, 1970). Recognition is based on familiarity, resemblance or similarity, and requires previous precedents to compare with.

Comprehension is about making 'sense of things', i.e. that products are "understandable to their users" (Krippendorff, 2006). Comprehension is the message about the product itself, includes how the product describes its purpose and use, and expresses its properties and performance.

Association is about communication of, e.g., values, origin and heritage, and works solely through the creation and interpretation of symbolic signs. As such, this sub mode is dependent on subjective and socio-culturally conditioned processes of coding, which determine how we associate references with meaning through symbolic signs within target market groups with similar values and aspirations; interpretative communities (Chandler, 2006).

In relation to Bling products, we regarded the PPE framework as useful for understanding the various motives, reasons and manifestations which were evident in the students' work. Compared to the other mentioned frameworks, the PPE framework provides more distinct categories for and categorising specific expressions of the students' work. This, we found useful for operationalising Bling in terms of product experiences



Figure 1. Framework of perceptual product experience (PPE), with core modes (centre) and the two dimensions of presentation (left) and representation (right) with sub modes.

METHOD

Due to the fact that Bling is perceived as a threat to good taste in a design context (cf. Bourdieu, 1984, Christoforidou et al, 2012), we expected that the Bling theme for a design task for our industrial design students would work as a provocation; that it would challenge and thereby trigger the students' subconscious values and prejudices (cf. Garfinkel, 1967; de Bono, 1973). Bling products represent much more than their actual appearance. A whole sub-culture and lifestyle is connected to these products (e.g. Christoforidou and Olander, 2009, 2010). Although it is a limited part of Bling, for this context we have chosen to focus on the visual expression of Bling products and the emotional reaction they trigger. Therefore, in a context of a trend course for industrial design students, we focused on the transformation of the industrial design student's descriptions of their own pre-understanding and interpretations of the cultural phenomenon of Bling. In total, nine master students attended the course, which was a voluntary course outside the frame of the mandatory course curriculum. The students were an international group mainly from Scandinavia, Central and South Europe and Central America. However as design students, they have all been trained within a common context, the 'design culture' which supports (to some degree) homogeneous values regarding aesthetics, taste and 'good design' (cf. McCracken's curator theory, 1988). The course's design brief was to design a future Bling concept. In addition, the students were given inspirational input in the form of lectures on different topics related to trends, e.g. status, taste, forecasting, product identity and product experience. In order to help them move forward with their design process, we gave them two additional assignments. Firstly, they were tasked to research Bling historically and visualize what Bling meant to them by using mood boards as a medium. Secondly, they were assigned to visualize Bling in mass media today. In this task, they studied how Bling is presented and represented by the media by collecting 10 up-to date examples of Bling, annotated with their own reflections.

As a part of their participation in the trend course, the students were asked to document their reflections in various ways, both regarding Bling as concept, as well as their own design process. By the end of the future Bling projects, the students were asked to write a self-reflective essay on the topic 'my Bling journey'. Since we had a premonition that the topic would be provocative for them to work with, we documented their immediate Bling associations before and after their work with the future Bling project.

POST-IT NOTE EXERCISE

Prior to providing any information on the students upcoming design project and lectures, we started out with a quick assignment in order to gather their very first reactions to Bling. Their reactions were elicited through two post it-note exercises, one pre-project and another one post-project.

We distributed and collected post-it notes stating the very first thing that came into the students' minds when the following questions were posed: When I say "Bling"…

- … which is the first word you associate to?
- … which is your first feeling?
- … which is the first person you think of?
- … which is the first situation or event that comes into mind?
- … which is the first product you associate the word to?

As the students were not given the opportunity to prepare themselves through discussions or Internet researching etc., we received a spontaneous response, followed by two minutes for reflection. This exercise was later repeated by the end of the course, before the plenary presentations of their future Bling proposals. We listed their answers in relation to the five different categories, i.e. word, feeling, person, situation and product, and summarized their responses into mind-maps.

SELF-REFLECTIVE ESSAYS

In between the two post-it note exercises, the students worked on an individual design project with the brief to create a design concept that would bring Bling into the future. They were expected to visualize their final Bling proposals with free-hand or computer aided sketches. As a last assignment the students were asked to write an essay 'Your Bling journey' (3-5

A4 pages) where they summarized their design process along with their personal reflections. They were to reflect over whether and how their understanding, expansion and transformation of their Bling concept had evolved and developed during the design process and how this development had affected their project. The essays were to be handed in together with the final presentation of their future Bling proposals.

ANALYSIS

After the completion of the course, we analysed the students' work, processes and end-results using a content analysis inspired approach and categorised our data with the help of the PPE framework with the primary objective of shedding light on possible transformations the students went through during their design processes. We reviewed three types of output from the students; words collected using the post-it note exercises before and after their design work, presentations material used during the final project presentation, and the self-reflective essays in which the students were asked to describe and reflect over their understanding of Bling in relation to their work process. The PPE framework allowed us to structure the students' perceptions and identify patterns with respect to how Bling affected students and why.

The presentations and the self-reflective essays provided a rich source of insights into students' views, ideas, and transformations while working with their future Bling projects. The post it-note exercises differ from the self-reflective essays, both in character and depth, being just immediate words without any explanation so as to why. The structure, i.e. the five different categories in which the words are presented were defined by us in advance based on our pre-understanding of what Bling usually is associated to or how it is explained (Christoforidou and Olander 2008, 2010).

RESULTS

Regarding the post-it note exercises, it is interesting to mention that the most dramatic shift occurred with respect to feelings expressed by the students. In spite of the group being international, the initial pre-project reaction among the group was highly consistent and homogenous, exhibiting emotive reactions such as "disgust", "vulgar", "indifference", "shallow", "aversion" and "irks!". A collation of the words used by the students during the initial exercise is presented in Figure 2.

This initial reaction was contrasted by the post-project interpretations of Bling, see figure 3, where words such as "laugh", "proud" and "striving" were brought up. Subsequently, this attitude shift was reflected in the students' project outcomes presented directly following the final post-it note exercise.



Figure 2. Initial post-it note exercise: First Bling impressions in five categories.



Figure 3. Final post-it note exercise: Developed Bling impression.

On the next page, see figure 4, a student's pre-project Bling references are illustrated directly on the modes of the PPE framework, demonstrating how we have used the framework in our analysis.

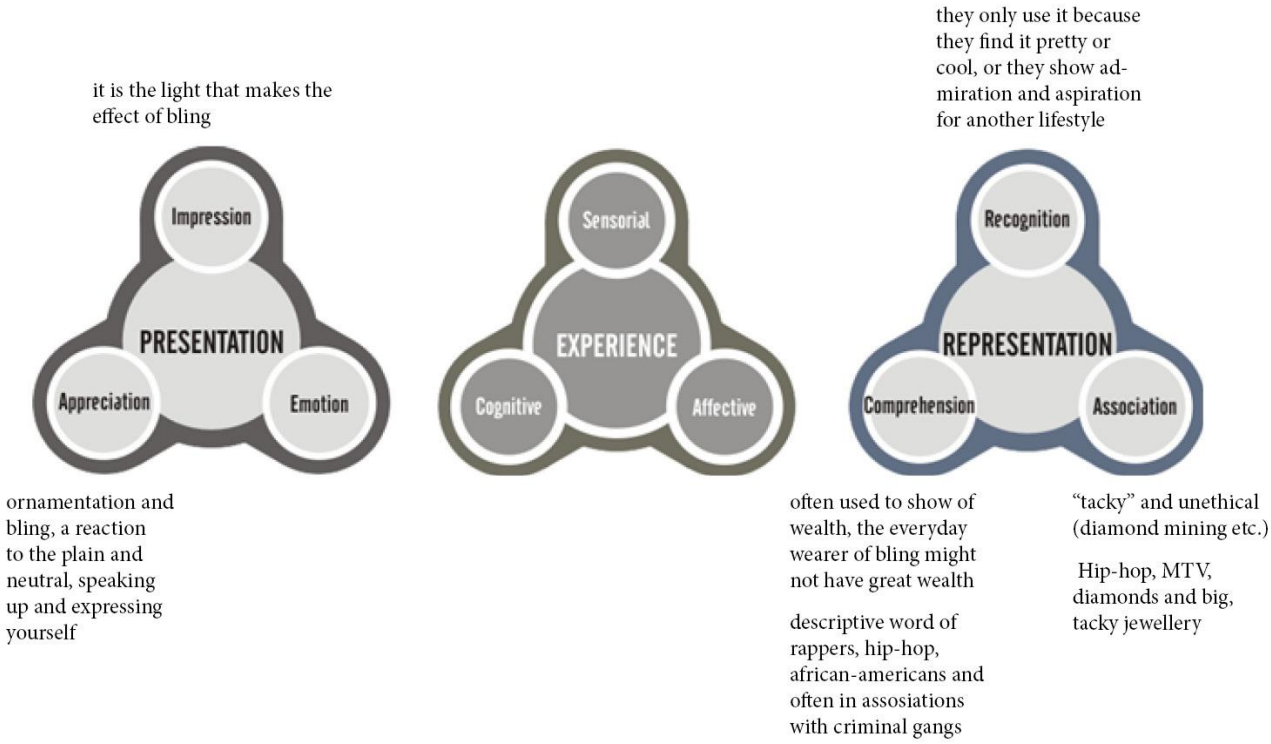


Figure 4. Pre-project Bling references experienced by a student (nr. 4) displayed on the modes of the PPE framework.

Student 1 transformed Bling from being about "taste problems" and creating ego-centric attention, to subtle Bling which is about the person, hiding the real self, to the merging of technology and jewellery in an electronic smart device providing hidden services that are useful in everyday life. These include key access, library card, lightings switch for the home, bus transit fee card, USB memory stick, and personal medical journal. For this student, it was important to transform Bling into something useful.

Student 2 transformed the essence of Bling from being about something quite useless, impractical and of show-off character to a symbolic statement, in suggesting a giant sized water tap for use in the bathroom (figure 5). The idea was based on the preciousness of access to clean water, and this was emphasized in a way which is consistent with the character of typical Bling objects being 'talking pieces'.



Figure 5. The Bling water tap: an example of a future Bling concept.

Student 3 suggested that as natural resources become more scarce, washing will not be as common in the future. Consequently, people would not keep their hair, and would instead use a piece of 'skull jewellery' (figure 6) which would substitute the decorative effect of hair and convey values of sustainability and wealth.

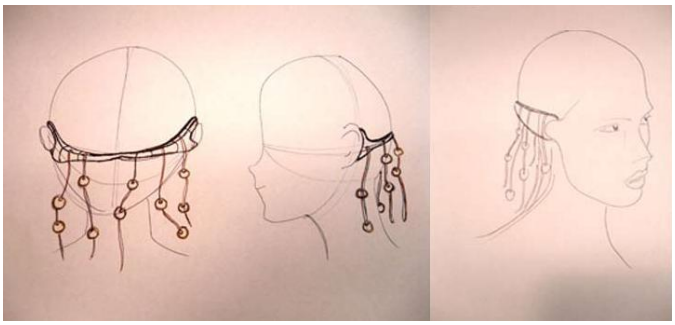


Figure 6. Another example of a future Bling concept: Skull jewellery.

Student 4 started out from the onomatopoetic origin of the word Bling, i.e. the imaginary sound of light reflected by diamonds. Light itself can thus be regarded as a carrier of the Bling essence, resulting in a lamp which in a rather excessive way generates “useless” light by spreading it indiscriminately in all directions. As such, it reflects the superfluous aspect of Bling, including “hints of old Hollywood dressing-room mirrors, the reflector refers to disco balls, cut precious stones and crystals” (see figure 7).



Figure 7. Final Bling concept by student 4: Future Bling Lamp



Figure 8. Final Bling concept by student 5: A fur footed side table

Student 5 created a side table which, in a future where everything will have to be sensible, practical and logical, can lighten up the mood by infusing a bit of Bling, see figure 8. The table has a slender and shiny chrome leg with a foot covered with fake fur, the bear foot being “a humorous take on the classical gilded lion’s feet, regarded as a stamp of luxury”. As it cannot carry much, is made out of chrome which as material stains easily, and has a fake fur covered “bear foot” which is very difficult to clean, the table is highly impractical and “overtly useless”. According to the student it is thus bad taste and ironic, “taking trashy hip-hop Bling to a new level and making it coded”.

Another student entered the Bling project from yet a different angle: eastern rock and punk references and the lifestyle they represent. He singled out the underground quality of Bling to be inspired by and transformed his references into a personal future Bling concept: tattooed leather chairs, see figure 9.



Figure 9. Bling concept in the form of tattooed leather chairs.

DISCUSSION

In order to reach a deeper level of understanding on the totality of perceptual experiences arising from non-instrumental interaction with products, in this paper we have explored the love and hate relationship Bling products seem to cause. How people relate to, and what they wish to signal, through products varies between cultures (Csikszentmihalyi and Rochberg-Halton, 1981). However, as a subculture, Bling employs extreme and provoking manifestations of identity, self-expression and status. The distinct, extreme character of Bling and its provoking aspects are interesting from a pedagogical perspective as a way to canalize the creative driving force in a design education context, but also challenge the normative and break subjective boundaries. In our experience, Bling seems to make people talk. When Bling related products or the issue of Bling itself is brought up, the communication becomes personal and sincere. People engage in honest discussions, coloured by their subjective values and beliefs, rather than ruling conventions. This can be exemplified by the fact that all our students recognized Bling products as being something 'different' and they found them to be un-functional with no other purpose than being decorative.

The students' dramatic change in perception regarding the concept of Bling becomes particularly evident when comparing the 'Pre' and the 'Post' columns of the different modes within the PPE framework (see table 1). The revised notion of Bling is evident in the product concepts; compared to 'traditional' Bling manifestations often found in popular culture. The students' interpretations are more subtle and suggests ingredients of a 'new Bling'.

The PPE framework has helped us understand how the student transformed what Bling represented for

	Presentational aspects						Representational aspects					
	Impression		Appreciation		Emotion		Recognition		Comprehension		Association	
	Pre	Post	Pre	Post	Pre	Post	Pre	Post	Pre	Post	Pre	Post
Stud 1	-	-	Flashy colours	Sober	-	-	Style, gold, difference	Discrete	-	Assistance, Service; guidance	Hip hop, fake, taste problem	Useful, high-tech, money
Stud 2	-	-	Diamonds, shiny things, leather, pearls	Discrete, camoufla ged	-	-	Different from the rest	Original, talking piece	-	Integration between technology and nature	Status, glamour, expansive taste, bad taste, 'look at me'	Limitless water, individuality, authenticity, originality, naturality
Stud 3	Being notice	To be seen, attention	Jewellery, shiny, expensive, unchangeable, scarce, natural materials	simplicity	-	-	Dare to be different	-	unfunctional	functional	Shiny, flashy, conspicuous, royalty + power. The more you have the more you are worth. Provocation, status	Revolution, ideology, unpretentious, natural, expensive, durable
Stud 4	It is the light that makes the effect of bling	Other ways and objects that create the effect of bling	Ornamentation and bling, a reaction to the plain and neutral, speaking up and expressing your-self	Simpler decoratio ns, refraction , sparkle, natural, extravaga nt, blaze, crystal prism	-	-	They only use it because they find it pretty or cool, or they show admiration and aspiration for another lifestyle	Appear ing to be someth ing else, bling in disguise	Often used to show wealth, the everyday wearer of bling might not have great wealth	-	'tacky' and unethical (diamond mining etc)	Cultural branding, less need to be obvious, postmodernity , hybridity, transformality, ecobility, simplicity, disparate, individuality
Stud 5	Obvio us and uncode d	-	Diamonds, gold, jewellery, 'blinged'up' regular products	-	-	-	Lavish, indulgent	-	Flashing wealth, or trying to flash wealth, impractical, it has no purpose beyond being decorative	-	Working and lower middle classes or newly wealthy, fake, it's not about what it costs, but how you do it	

Table 1. PPE framework in tabular form: Student's pre- and post-project Bling experiences.

them in order to be able to use Bling as a creative force. In general, the students changed their view from recognising a product as Bling, e.g. identifying the product as an icon of Bling (using Peirce, 1966, semiotic signs), to seeing a product as being associated to Bling, e.g. identifying the product as a symbol of Bling. This can be exemplified with the students self-reports, see table 1. Student 1 for example, described Bling by using words representing the icon of Bling i.e. hip hop, fake, taste problem, whereas the same student later on described Bling as useful and high-tech, thus becoming the new symbol of Bling. This transformation can also be seen in other student projects, where for example student 4 designed a lamp associated to Bling's origin, the imaginary sound of light being reflected in a diamond. The diamonds aren't there anymore, however, with her design, the student has tried to visualise the reflection of light becoming a symbol of Bling instead of an icon. For someone looking at her lamp, the icon of Bling might be difficult to detect. Had she kept the diamonds, the Bling icon would have remained. Therefore the lamp without a description of her sources of inspiration will not automatically be recognised as Bling. By transforming the icon of Bling into a personal symbol, the students were able to use Bling as their creative driving force in their projects.

Although the size of the group of students taking part in the Trends course was too small to serve as a basis to draw general conclusions, it was quite interesting to note the different entries and orders in their approaches and understanding. The Bling features the students chose to be guided by in their creative process towards unconventional future Bling concepts were among others: the sense of humour that characterizes some Bling expressions, the bombastic and pompous form language, the rarity and exclusivity of the materials involved, the un-necessity of it and the rebellious aspects. The students that were positive towards functionalism and minimalism seemed less prone to kitsch and Bling; they engaged the Bling project with a more mental, intellectual approach. Although they were open to question themselves and their initial reactions towards Bling on an intellectual level, in practice they preferred being inspired by and work with the immaterial qualities of Bling. They chose to emphasize on the humoristic twist that Bling products often communicate and the sparkling, twinkling play of light that Bling jewellery reflect. While some students were more careful in adopting bombastic Bling features, others seemed less restrained by the fear of being tacky or proposing tasteless concepts. They worked on a more intuitive and associative level during the initial phases. Perhaps they had access to cultural references including extrovert form language to be inspired and guided by in their work.

HOW BLING IS PRESENTED

After categorizing our data by using the pleasure-dominate presentational aspects (*impression, appreciation and emotion*), we could notice that the students' perceptions of Bling products shifted. The majority of the students' initial opinions regarded Bling as something quite far from their own taste references and preferences. This became evident through the spontaneous post-it elicitation exercise as well.

To exemplify and clarify the reason for this emotional/attitude shift, we have highlighted some of their arguments from their project documentation and the self-reflective essays. Rather dominant shifts in perception were evident in the PPE framework's experience mode of Appreciation, see table 1, were in the beginning of the course for instance, the students used words such as: flashy colours, diamonds, shiny things, pearls, jewellery, expensive, ornamentation, speaking up, expressing your-self, gold to describe Bling. Whereas by the end of the course, they used words describing Bling as: sober, discrete, camouflaged, simple and decorative. This indicates that they changed the way of how they recognize the aesthetic value of Bling.

HOW BLING IS REPRESENTED

However we could also notice a shift in the students' perception of Bling after categorizing our data using the meaning-dominate representational aspects (*recognition, comprehension and association*) of product experiences. For these aspects we could only use the students' self-reflective reports. Here, the most dramatic shift occurred in the PPE framework's experience mode of Association, see table 1. In the beginning of the project, the students used words like: fake, taste problems, bad taste, 'look at me', flashy,

provocation, power, ‘tacky’ and unethical. Whereas by the end of the course, they used words like: useful, high-tech, individual, authentic, original, revolutionary, natural, durable, culture branding and simple instead. This illustrates that the students changed their view on what Bling communicate as a symbolic sign. There was a shift regarding the modes of Recognition and Comprehension as well, it was however not as prominent as for the mode Association.

THE ROLE OF THE DESIGNER

Design is highlighted as the tool for creating competitive advantages, creating things differently, and changing things for the better (Forty, 1986; Simon, 1997). In their professional capacity, designers are supposed to relate to people's lives and situations in an empathic manner and find inspiration beyond the limits of their own contexts and subjective values.

The values the students shared within the context of the common culture of the design community proved to be stronger than their respective backgrounds, thus leading to more homogenous values and reactions towards the controversial theme of Bling then we initially expected to find (cf. Bourdieu’s habitus 1984 and McCracken’s curator theory 1988). The negative connotations of Bling expressed initially during the course however, did not seem to have a negative effect on their devotion to the project. Instead, the challenge provided through the task of understanding Bling in design terms eventually turned to a rich source of inspiration and creativity.

In the creation and maintenance of cultural phenomena, products and physical attributes are often employed to communicate values and identity. We believe that the understanding of such manifestations can be useful for design practice and may even contribute to change the role of the designer from a reactive to a proactive agent of change. In order to become empowered to take part in that change, and through designing appropriate associations and meanings, designers could prepare actively and consciously through establishing a deep understanding of relevant cultural characteristics. This can be a challenge for design students, who are simultaneously engaging in the process of being immersed in and establishing their own identity through the creation of normative codes within the design community.

Designers’ various roles are sometimes surrounded by sets of values that can be elitist and myopic rather than open and inclusive. It is therefore important to try to break down any reigning consensus of monoculture that may exist within the design community. If we are to assume that design to some extent is a monoculture with a strong sense of consensus, regarding aesthetic values not to say the least, it is important not to neglect to cease every possible opportunity to rearrange and refurnish the foundations that constitute any inherent ‘Designology’. By adopting a critical and empathic perspective through proactively working with the idea of informed provocation, designers are enabled to reflect over their role and to hopefully contribute to a more open society rather than merely being reactive to changes.

As we have seen, in the case of the future Bling projects, the students managed to transform how they perceived Bling but also how they viewed their own roles as designers.

CONCLUSION

In the described study, design students were challenged to confront and work with a subculture which to a high degree utilizes designed artefacts to communicate very specific messages and create a strong identity. Rather than adopting an alienating position, they were enabled and motivated to single out and understand relevant stimuli and messages in order to create, manage, transform and situate these references into positive and meaningful contexts and human habitats – as empathic interpreters and transformational agents, a critical skill for designers. This increased sensibility helps furnish our lives with less predictable, less conventional, highly personal and surprising objects/artefacts.

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